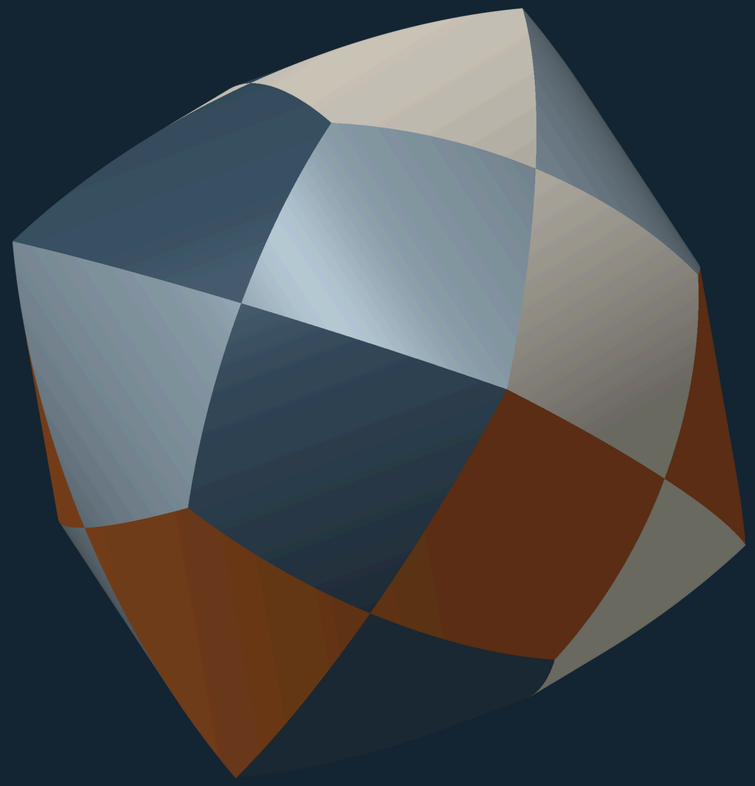
NLD

NONLINEAR DYNAMICS LABORATORY



Differentiating and integrating measured motion

Model-free kinematics from one sensor or two

github.com/nld-uri/kinematics-toolbox

Nonlinear Dynamics Laboratory · University of Rhode Island

THE PROBLEM

Two problems every vibration lab has

The setting: one sensor type, and you need the other kinematic quantities

You measured displacement (laser vibrometer, DIC, encoder) and you need velocity and acceleration.

Restoring-force surfaces, NNM energy balance, damping identification, model updating.

You measured acceleration (the cheap, rugged, ubiquitous sensor) and you need velocity and displacement.

Mode shapes in physical units, drift-free response, base-excitation compensation, fatigue cycles.

Both are routine requests. Both are harder than they look.

The naive answers — finite differences one way, cumulative trapezoid the other — fail, and fail differently.

THE PROBLEM

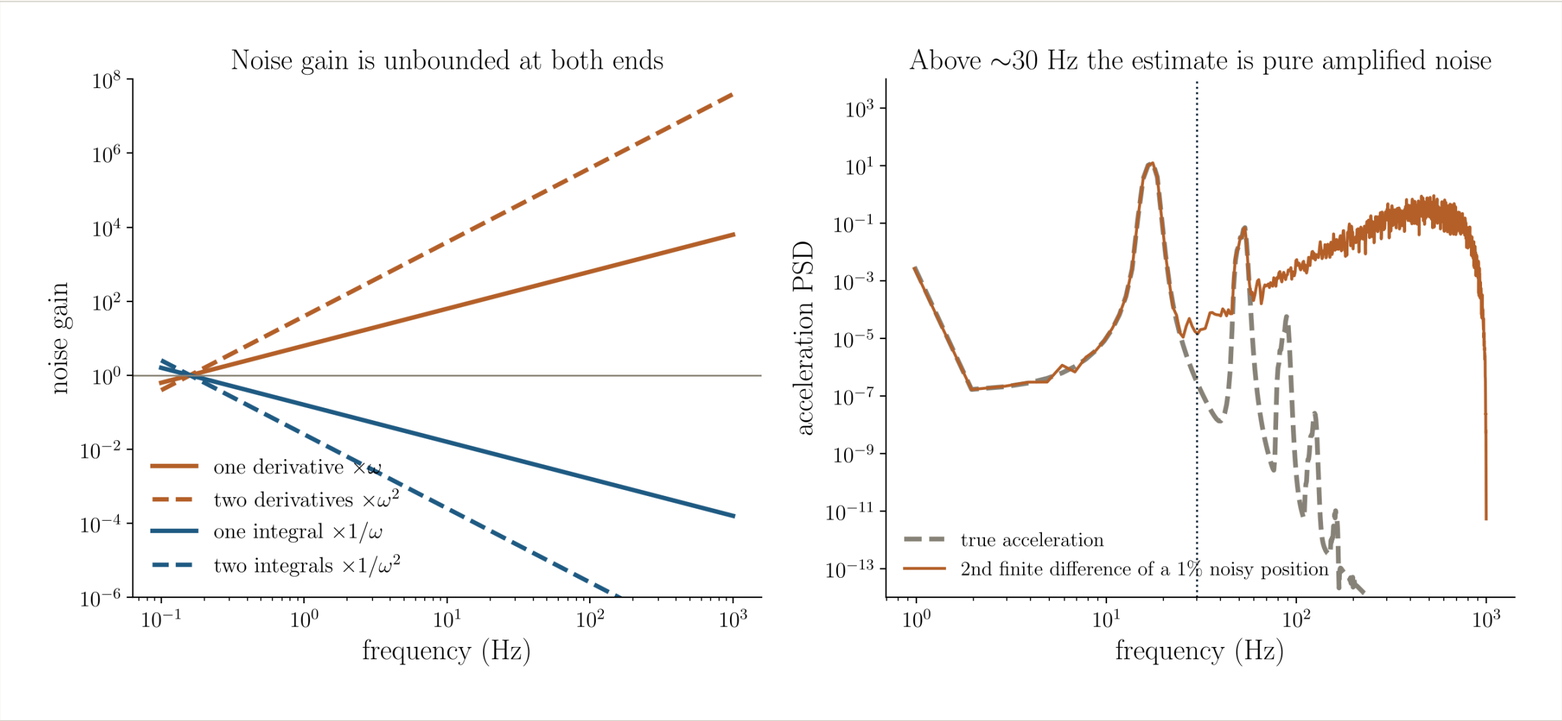
They are the same problem, run in opposite directions

One framing that organizes the whole landscape

- Write the measurement as $y = Au + e$, with A the integration operator.
- Differentiation: u is the derivative you want, A integrates it back to what you measured.
- Integration: u is the displacement, A integrates the acceleration twice.
- **A is compact. Its inverse is unbounded.** This is the definition of an ill-posed inverse problem.
- Noise is amplified without limit — by ω per derivative going up, by $1/\omega$ per integration going down.
- No amount of cleverness removes this. It is a property of the operator, not of your algorithm.
- Every usable method therefore adds a regularity prior. That is the only thing that distinguishes them.

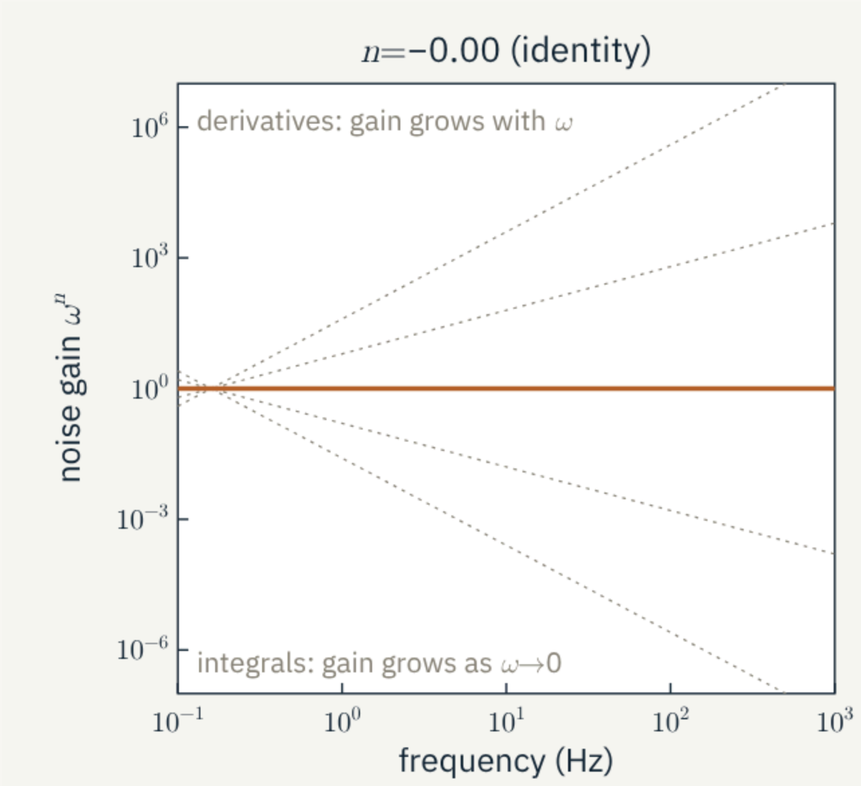
THE PROBLEM

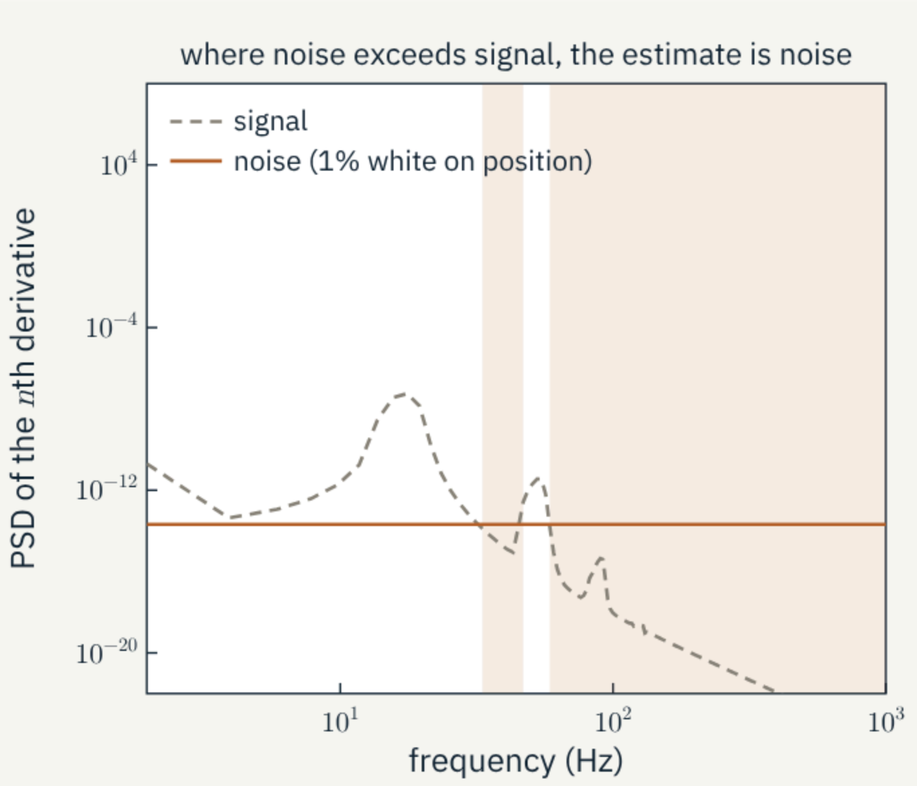
Why it is ill-posed



Left: the amplification factor is unbounded at both ends. Right: the same effect on a real record — a 1% noise floor on position dominates the acceleration estimate above about 30 Hz.

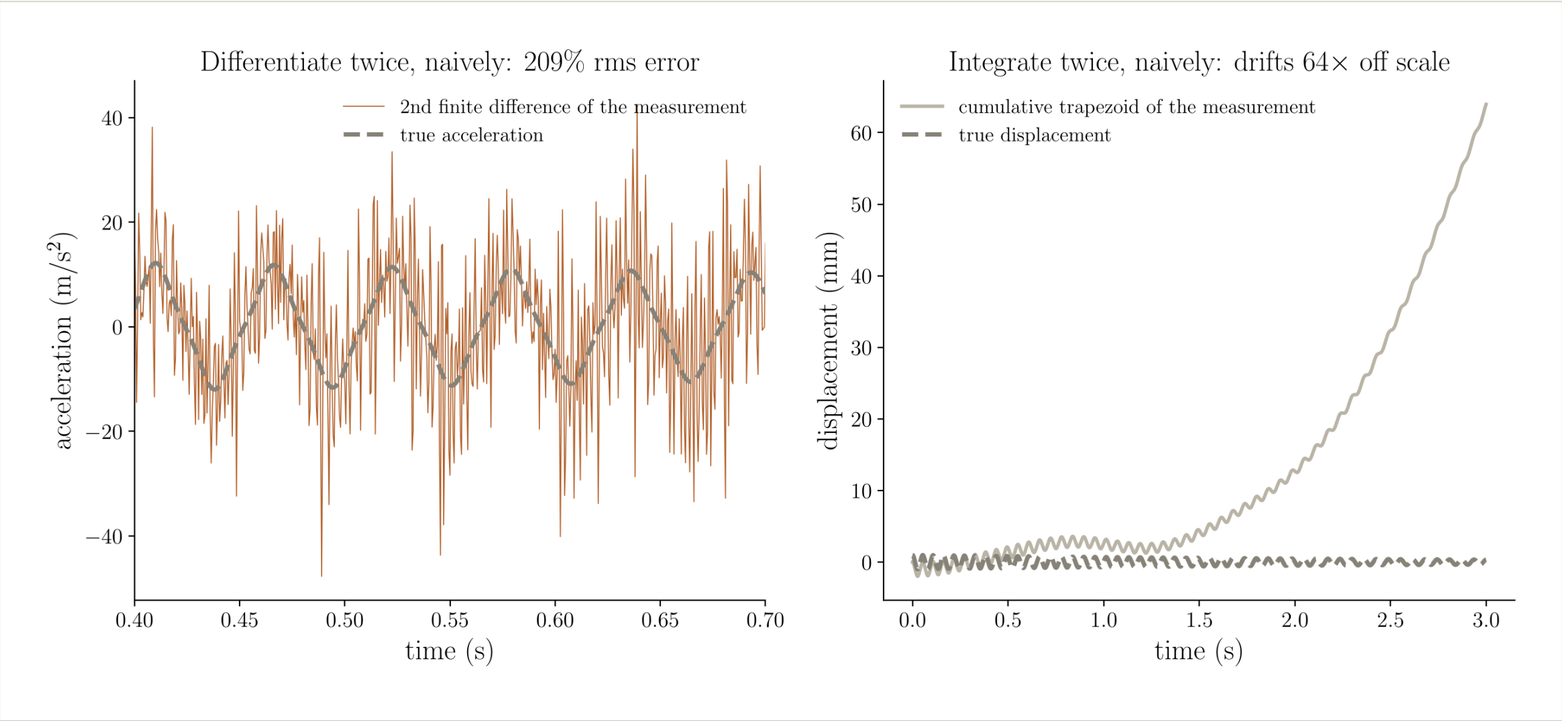
Differentiation and integration: one gain, opposite ends





THE PROBLEM

What happens if you ignore it



Left: second central difference of a 1% noisy position — 209% rms error. Right: plain cumulative trapezoid of an accelerometer with a 0.5% offset — 64x off scale in 3 s.

THE PROBLEM

The only cure: state a prior

Methods differ only in which regularity prior they impose — pick the row you actually believe

What you are willing to assume	The method it gives you
The signal is bandlimited and periodic	Spectral / FFT differentiation
It is locally a low-order polynomial	Savitzky–Golay, Lanczos
It lies in a low-rank delay-embedding subspace	Delay SVD (SSA) / SOD — now in the toolbox
Its p-th derivative is small in L_2	Whittaker–Henderson, Tikhonov, smoothing spline
Its derivative is piecewise constant (L_1)	Total variation (Chartrand)
It is an integrated Wiener process	Kalman / RTS smoother $\equiv$ Gaussian process
Its third derivative is bounded by a known constant	Levant sliding-mode (causal, online)

01

Differentiation methods



Spectral (FFT) differentiation: strengths

Multiply the spectrum by $(\mathrm{i}\omega)^n$, roll off above a cutoff, transform back.

STRENGTHS

- Exact for a bandlimited periodic signal — no discretisation error at all
- Most accurate of any method in the interior of a long record (0.54% velocity error here)
- Trivial to implement, $\mathcal{O}(N \log N)$, and the cutoff has an obvious physical meaning
- The natural choice when you already work in the frequency domain

Spectral (FFT) differentiation: limitations

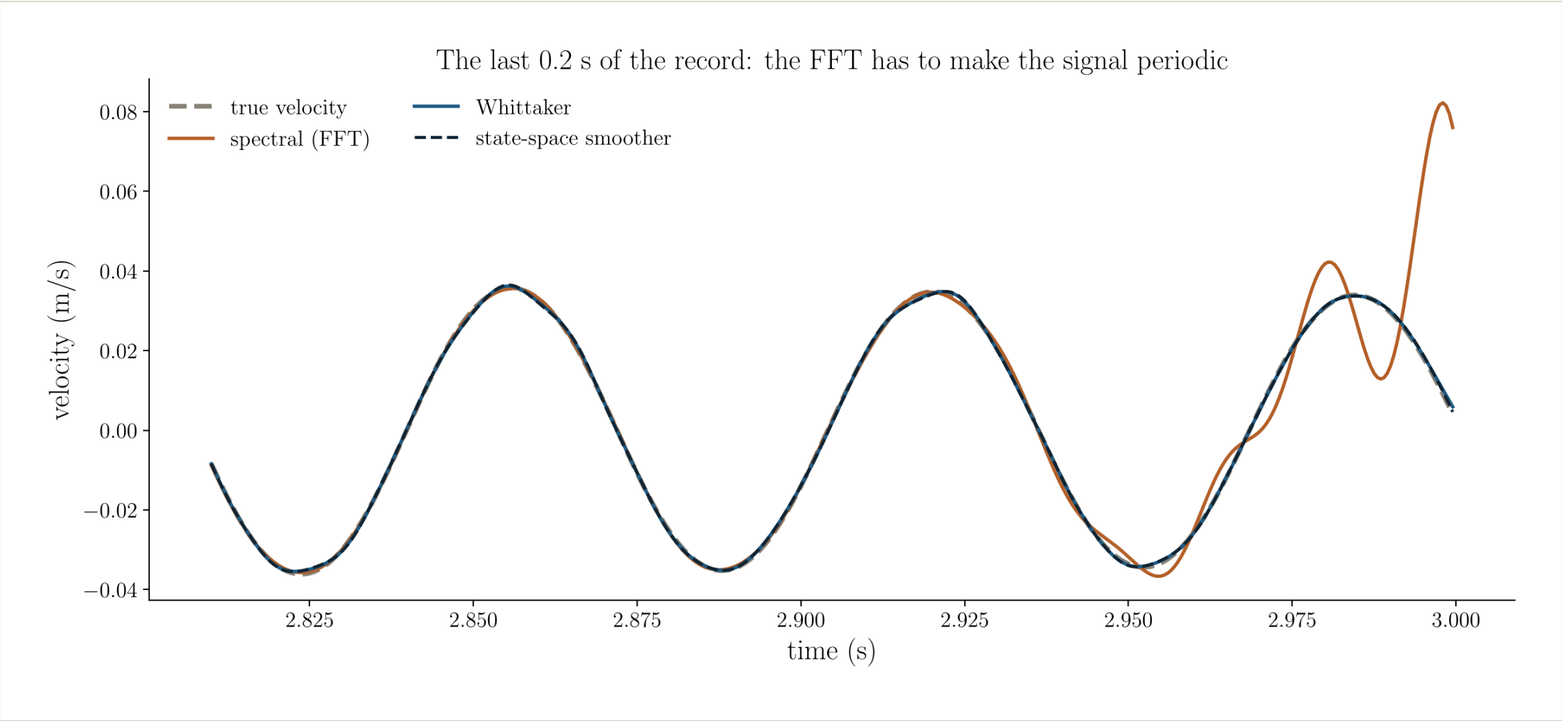
LIMITATIONS

- Enforces periodicity — catastrophic at the record ends (next slide)
- Needs uniform sampling and a gap-free record
- Cutoff must be chosen; too high amplifies noise, too low removes signal
- Leakage if the record is not an integer number of periods (taper, then divide it out)

> **Use it when** The record is long, uniformly sampled, and you only care about the middle of it.

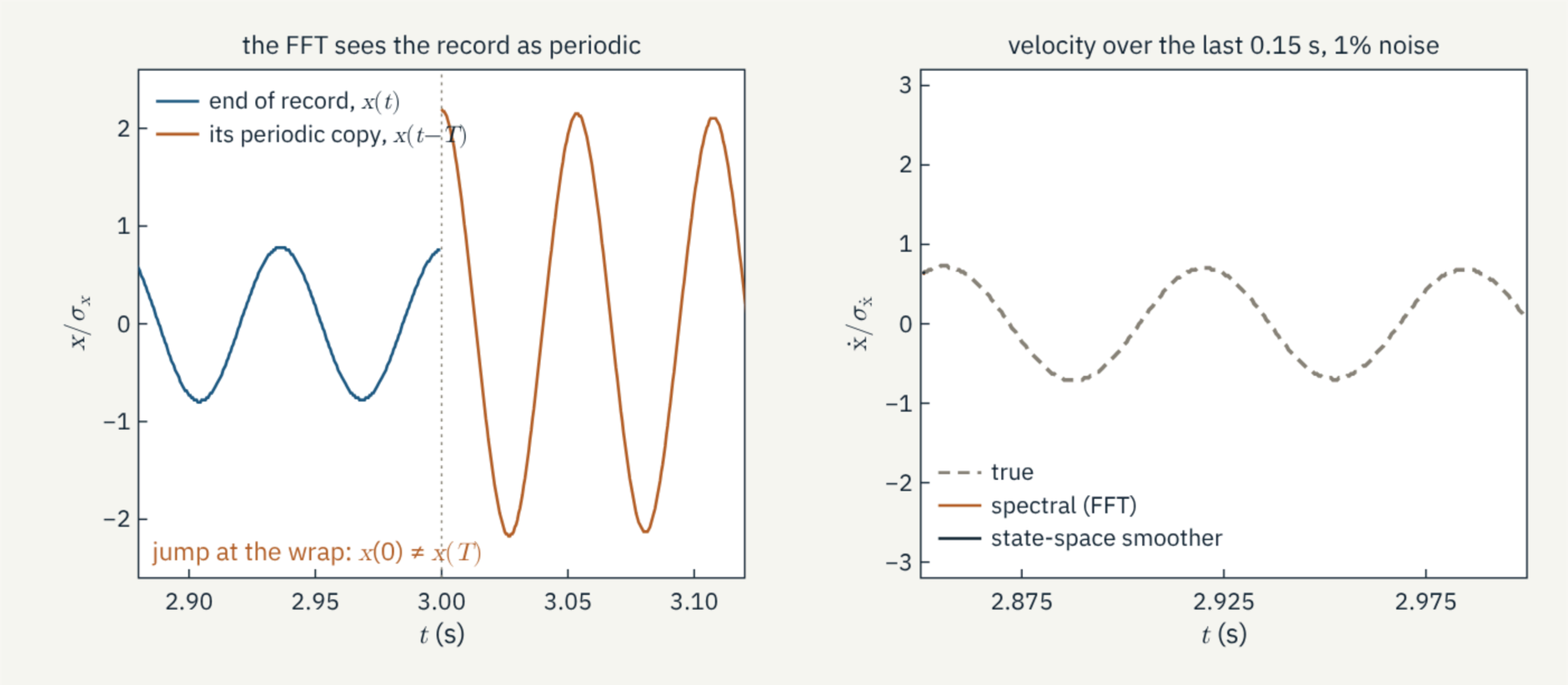
DIFFERENTIATION

The FFT caveat that costs people real results



Velocity over the last 0.2 s of a 3 s free decay. Interior error 0.54%; over the full record, 8.4% — a 15x degradation.

Why the FFT fails at the ends of the record



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Savitzky–Golay: strengths

Fit a low-order polynomial in a sliding window; differentiate the polynomial analytically.

STRENGTHS

- Simple, fast, and available in every toolbox
- No periodicity assumption — much better behaved at the ends than the FFT
- Preserves peak heights and widths better than a plain moving average
- Window length maps to a cutoff via Schafer’s rule, so it can be set from physics

Savitzky–Golay: limitations

LIMITATIONS

- Two knobs (window, polynomial order) that interact
- Implicitly assumes the signal is polynomial over the window — poor for lightly damped resonance
- Noticeably worse than an L_2 penalty for second derivatives (2.4% vs 0.9% here)
- Edge behaviour depends on the padding convention, which differs between implementations

Use it when You want something defensible in ten lines with no linear solve, and first derivatives are enough.

Whittaker–Henderson and Tikhonov: strengths

Penalise the p-th derivative in L_2: $\min_s \|s - x\|^2 + \lambda \|D^p s\|^2$. *One banded solve.*

STRENGTHS

- One sparse banded solve — $\mathcal{O}(N)$, no iteration, no convergence to check
- Flat accuracy across the whole record, ends included
- λ has a closed-form map to a cutoff frequency, so no blind parameter sweep
- Same machinery runs the integration direction (Tikhonov) — one implementation, both tasks

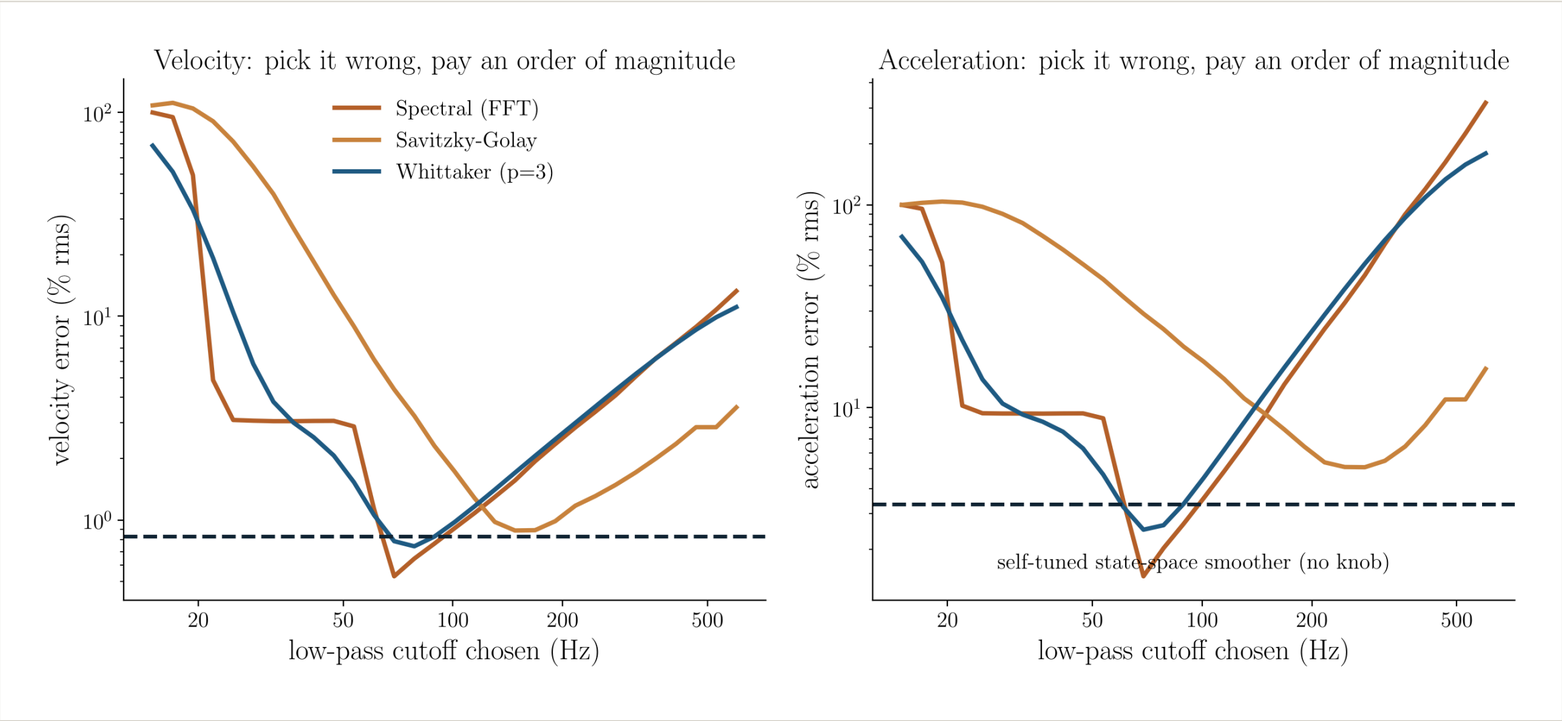
Whittaker–Henderson and Tikhonov: limitations

LIMITATIONS

- Still one knob, and the optimum is sharp for second derivatives
- Quadratic penalty rounds off genuine corners — wrong prior for impacting systems
- The normal matrix is badly scaled; use a sparse direct solver, not an iterative one
- No uncertainty estimate comes out of it

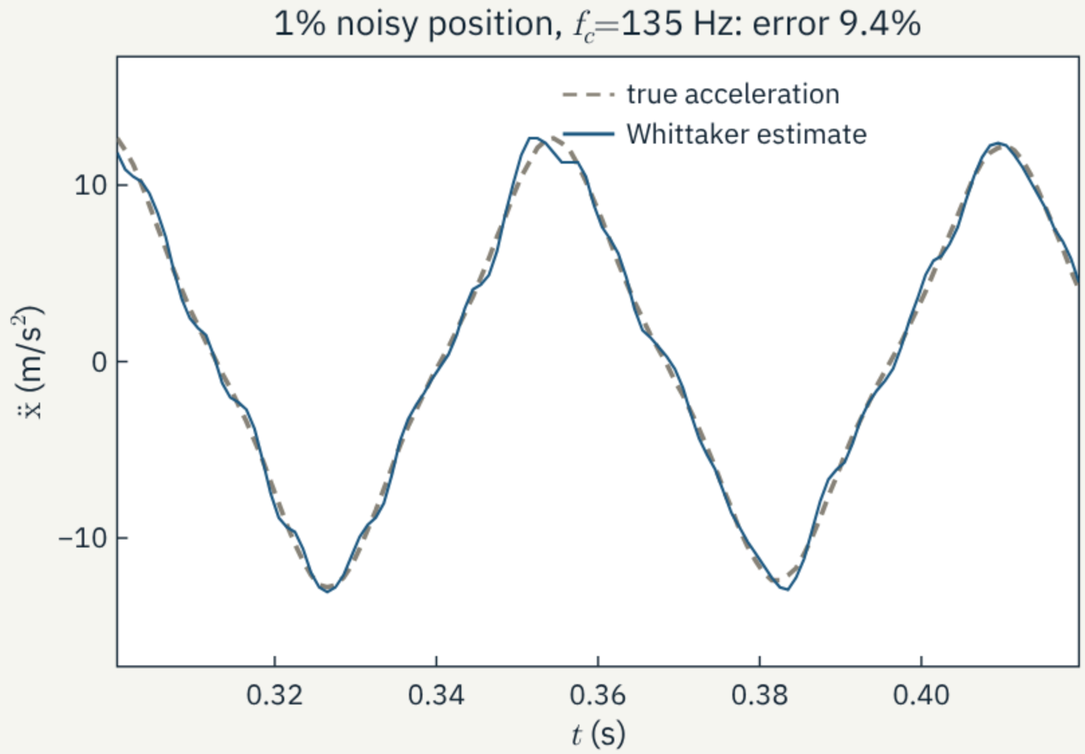
> **Use it when** This is the sensible default for smooth vibration data. Start here.

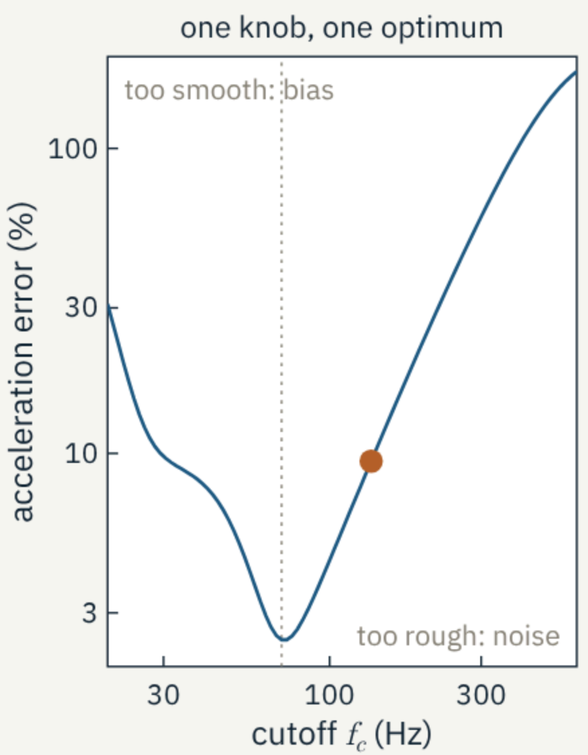
Every method has an optimum you have to find



Error against exact ground truth as the cutoff is swept, 1% position noise. The dashed line is the self-tuned state-space smoother, which has no knob at all.

One knob: sweeping the cutoff





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Setting the knob from physics, not from a sweep

Every L_2 method has a closed-form map from a corner frequency in Hz to its penalty weight

Method	Parameter	Rule	Set it from
Whittaker–Henderson (order p)	λ	$\lambda = (2\pi f_c)^{-2p}$	Highest mode you care about
Tikhonov integration (order n)	λ	$\lambda = (2\pi f_c)^{2n}$	Lowest frequency you trust
Savitzky–Golay	window $2M+1$	$f_c\,\Delta t \approx \dfrac{k+1}{3.2M - 4.6}$	Schafer's -3 dB rule
Spectral	cutoff	direct	Where the PSD meets the noise floor
Total variation	α	no closed form	Sweep; scale-sensitive, normalise first
State-space smoother	q	fitted automatically	Marginal likelihood — nothing to set

Total variation: strengths

Penalise $\|Du\|_1$ instead of $\|Du\|_2$. The L_1 norm does not punish a single large jump.

STRENGTHS

- The only family that preserves a genuine discontinuity in the derivative
- Best method tested at an impact: 16.9% vs 21–25% for every quadratic penalty
- Physically the right prior for impacts, stick–slip, backlash, dry friction reversal
- Recovers a piecewise-constant derivative exactly in the noise-free limit

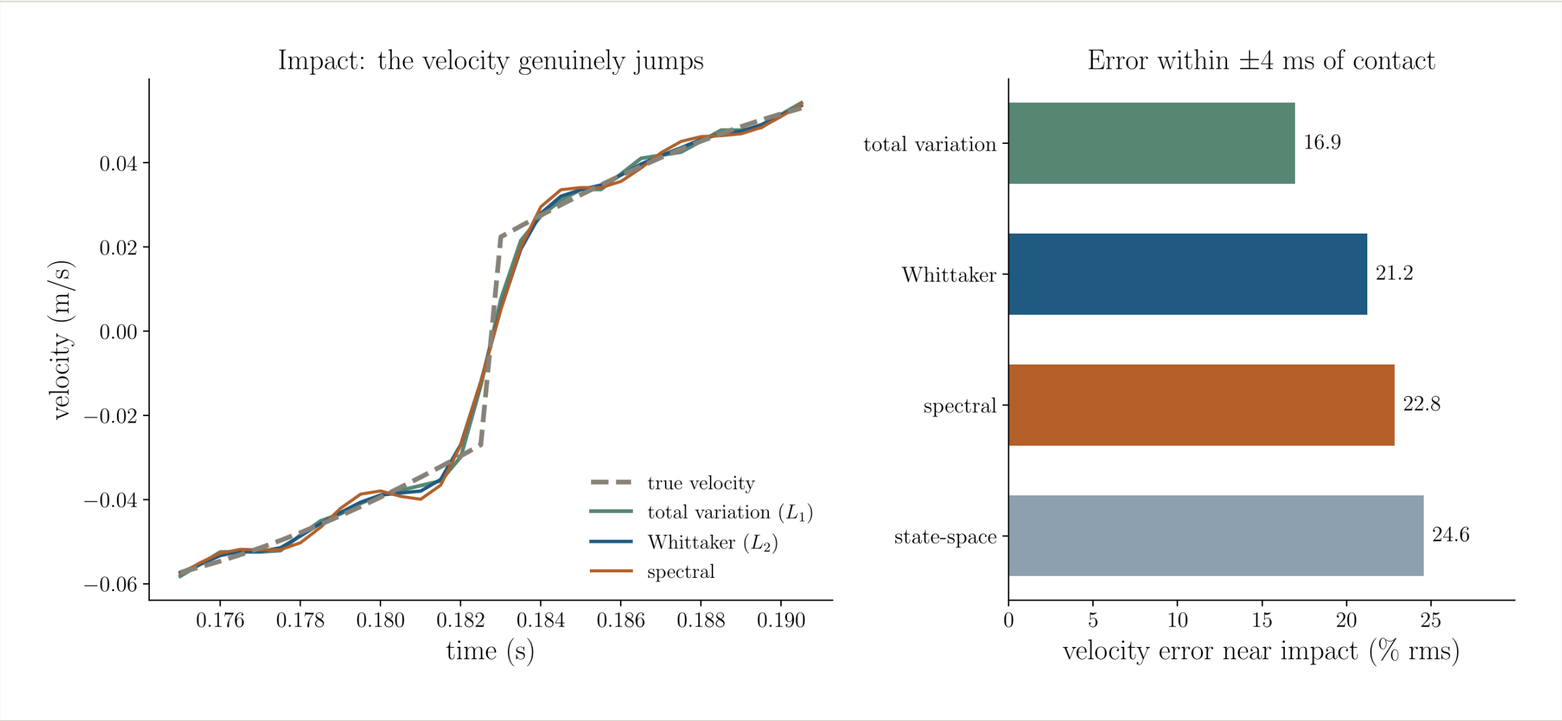
Total variation: limitations

LIMITATIONS

- Several times worse than an L_2 penalty on smooth signals — 5.1% vs 0.5% here
- Iterative, no closed form, and the objective is non-smooth
- α is tied to absolute signal scale — normalize before, rescale after
- The naive solver silently fails to converge (next slide)

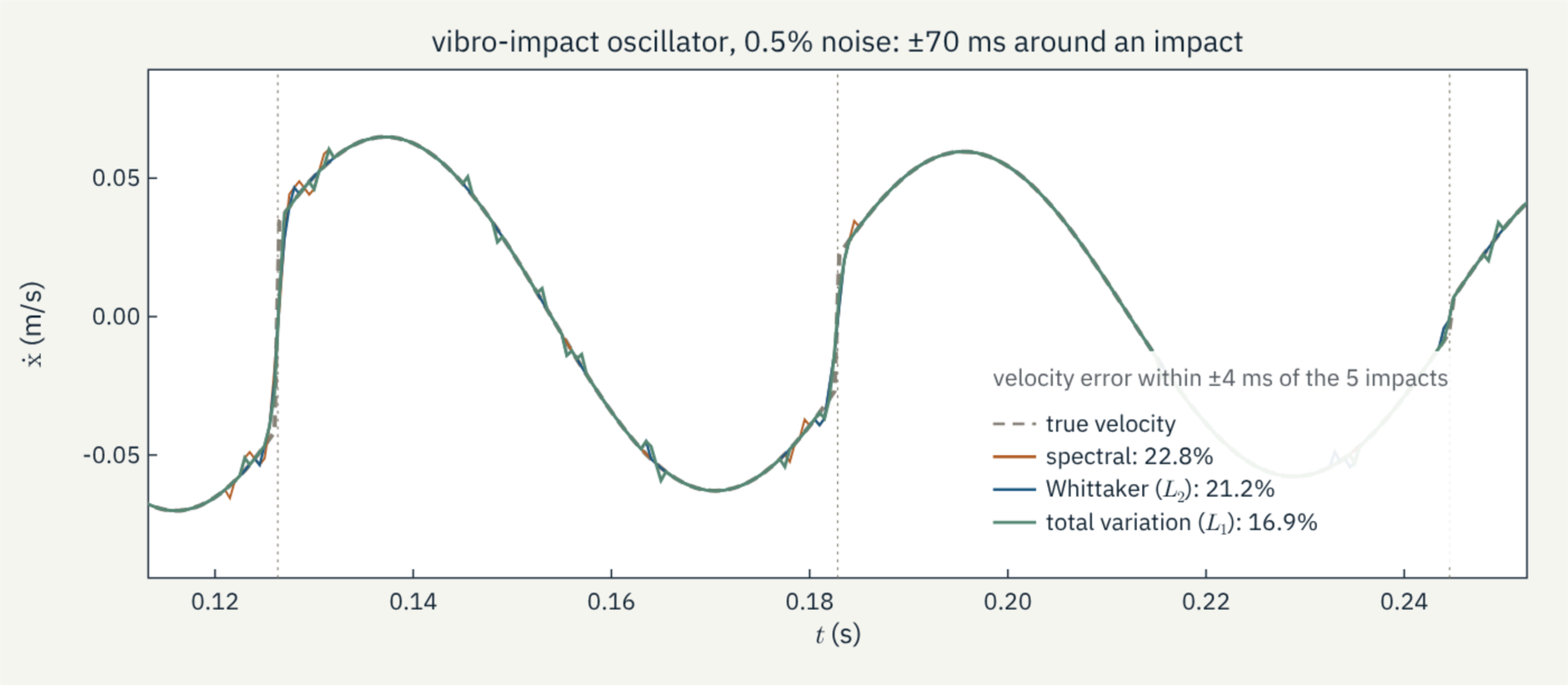
Use it when Your derivative genuinely jumps. Otherwise do not — it is the wrong prior for smooth data.

Where total variation earns its place



Vibro-impact oscillator, restitution 0.85. Left: one impact, velocity jumps. Right: velocity error within ±4 ms of contact, best setting per method.

At an impact, total variation tracks the jump most closely



A cautionary tale: the solver was the result

Reported numbers for an iterative method are claims about the solver as much as the estimator

- Chartrand's formulation has a dense, severely ill-conditioned Hessian $A^{\mathsf{T}}A + \alpha L$.
- Conjugate gradients stalls at any iteration cap. IRLS on the smoothed L_1 stalls too — measured rate 0.997 per iteration.
- The unconverged iterate acts as extra smoothing and silently changes the answer.
- MATLAB's pcg warns. scipy's cg returns the same unconverged vector with no warning at all.
- Three successive solvers moved the same benchmark:

Under-convergence flattered the method in both directions

smooth signal	near impacts
3.77% → 4.93% → **5.07%**	17.9% → 16.6% → **19.2%**

- Under-convergence had been flattering the method in both directions. Only the last pair is the true minimizer.
- Fix: substitute $w = Au$ to get L_1 trend filtering — the ADMM system is pentadiagonal and constant, so it factors once.

Smoothing spline: scipy’s GCV choice returned a flat fit

Found while porting to MATLAB; both are fixed in both languages

SMOOTHING SPLINE

- scipy’s make_smoothing_spline picks λ by GCV. On the 6000-point decay it returned a flat fit: 100% error.
- The exact GCV score, with an $\mathcal{O}(N)$ trace, has a clear minimum: 1.18% velocity error. The failure was the implementation, not GCV.

Levant: the default bound was 100× too small

LEVANT DIFFERENTIATOR

- Levant's default bound L used the $(n+1)$-th derivative. The three-state form needs the third derivative bound for both outputs.
- L was about 100× too small: 119% error. With max|jerk| from the state-space smoother: 7.7%, at the swept optimum.

Neither raised an error. Each returned a plausible-looking array.

Same lesson as the solver slide: check a default against a case where you know the answer.

State-space: the Kalman / RTS kinematic smoother: strengths

Model the signal as an integrated random walk; state = $(x,\ v,\ a,$ jerk, $\dots)$. Smooth, do not filter.

STRENGTHS

- Self-tuning — the single parameter q is fitted by marginal likelihood, no sweep
- Handles gaps, non-uniform sampling and multirate channels natively (NaN = missing)
- Returns a posterior standard deviation — error bars, not just an estimate
- Does differentiation, integration AND sensor fusion with one implementation
- $\mathcal{O}(N)$, and equivalent to a Gaussian process without the $\mathcal{O}(N^3)$

State-space: the Kalman / RTS kinematic smoother: limitations

LIMITATIONS

- Costs something against a perfectly tuned method on very clean data (up to 3.7×)
- The prior is smoothness — it rounds corners just as the L_2 penalties do
- More code than a banded solve; the likelihood optimisation needs a sane bracket
- Bias states are weakly identified over short records — a drift absorber, not a calibration

Use it when You want one tool that covers every case, or you have two sensors, or you need uncertainty.

DIFFERENTIATION

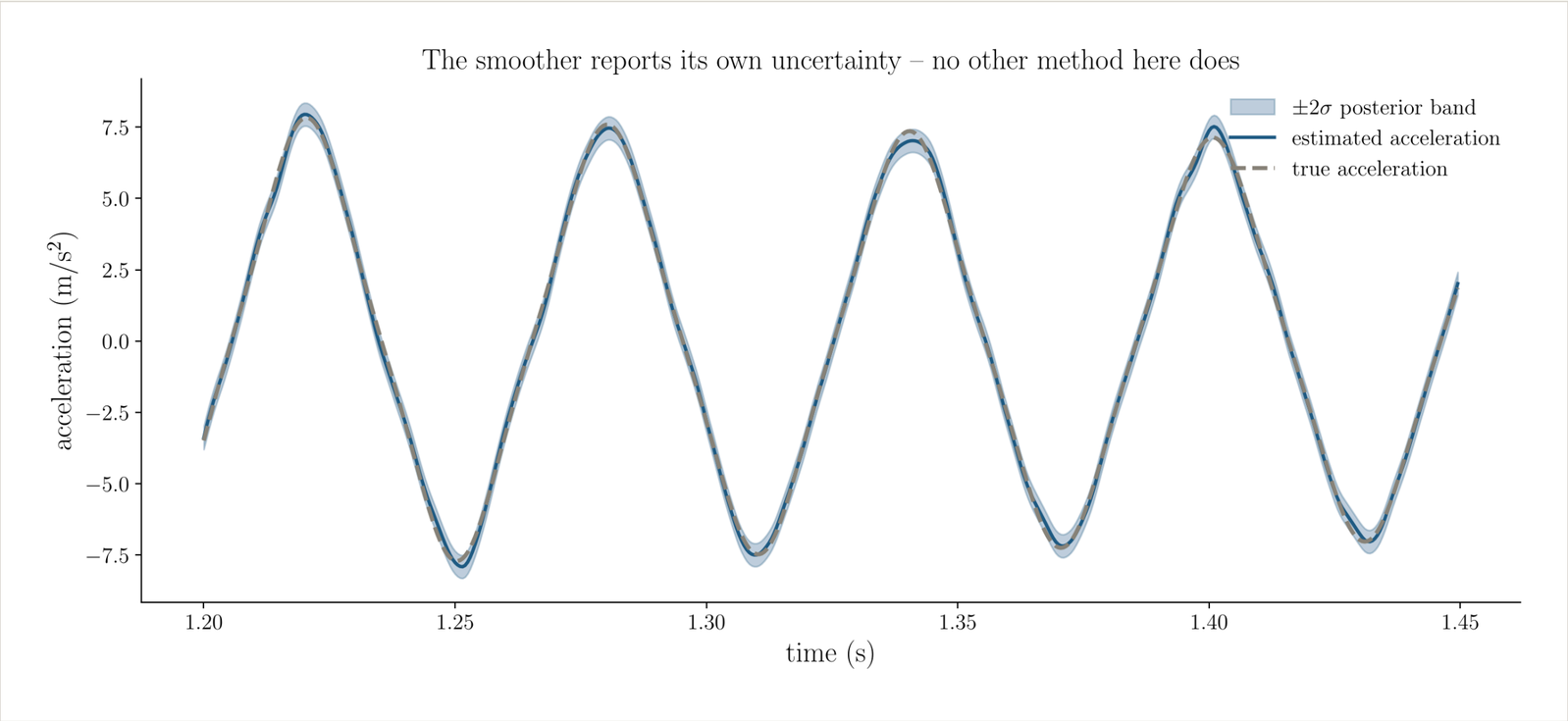
What does self-tuning actually cost?



Ratio of the self-tuned error to the best error achieved by ANY method in this study with its knob tuned against ground truth.

DIFFERENTIATION

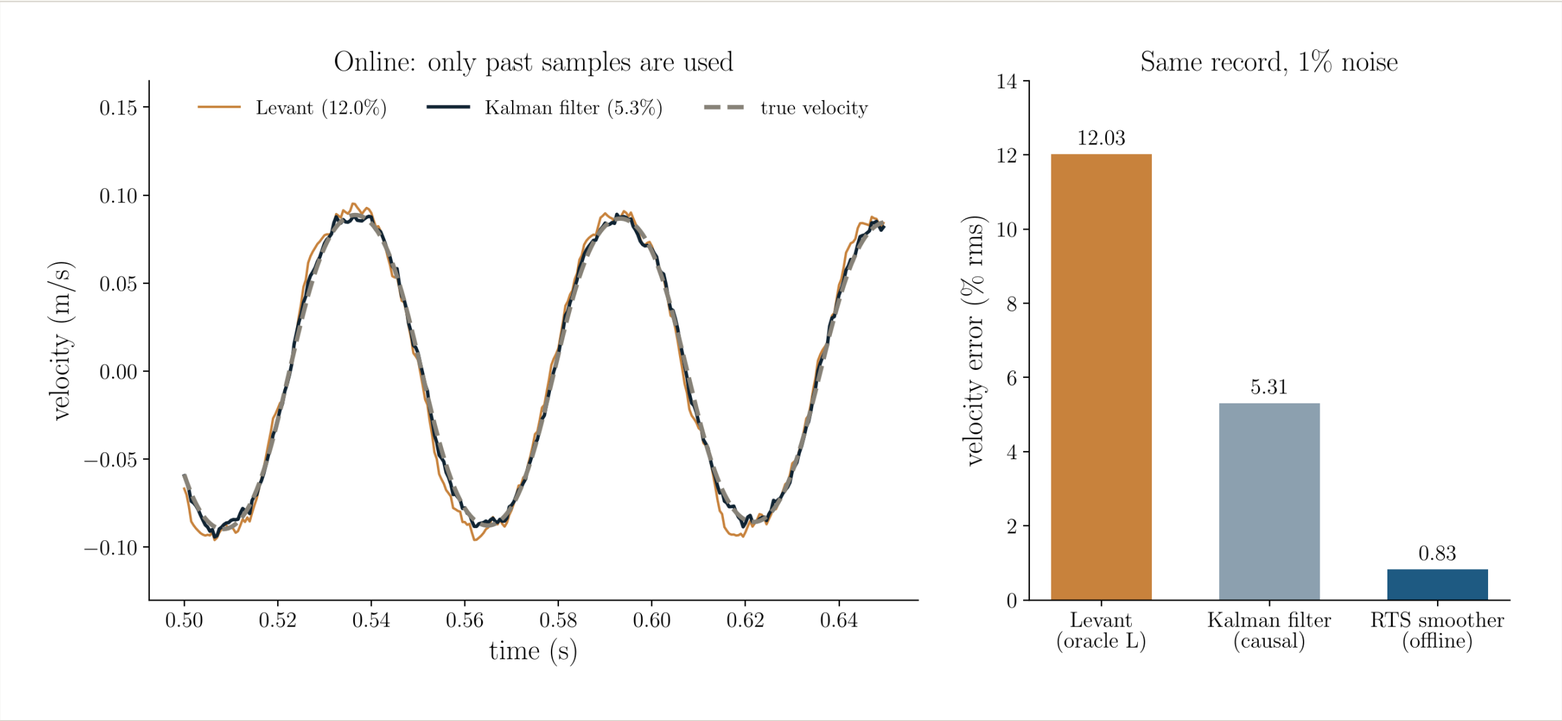
It tells you how much to trust it



Acceleration from a noisy position record with its $\pm 2\sigma$ posterior band. No other method in this comparison produces one.

DIFFERENTIATION

Online, the Kalman filter halves Levant’s error



Forward pass of the same state-space model, self-tuned: 5.3% velocity error against 12.0% for Levant at its best bound. Offline, the RTS smoother reaches 0.83%.

02

Delay reconstruction



Differentiate in the delay space, not on the raw record

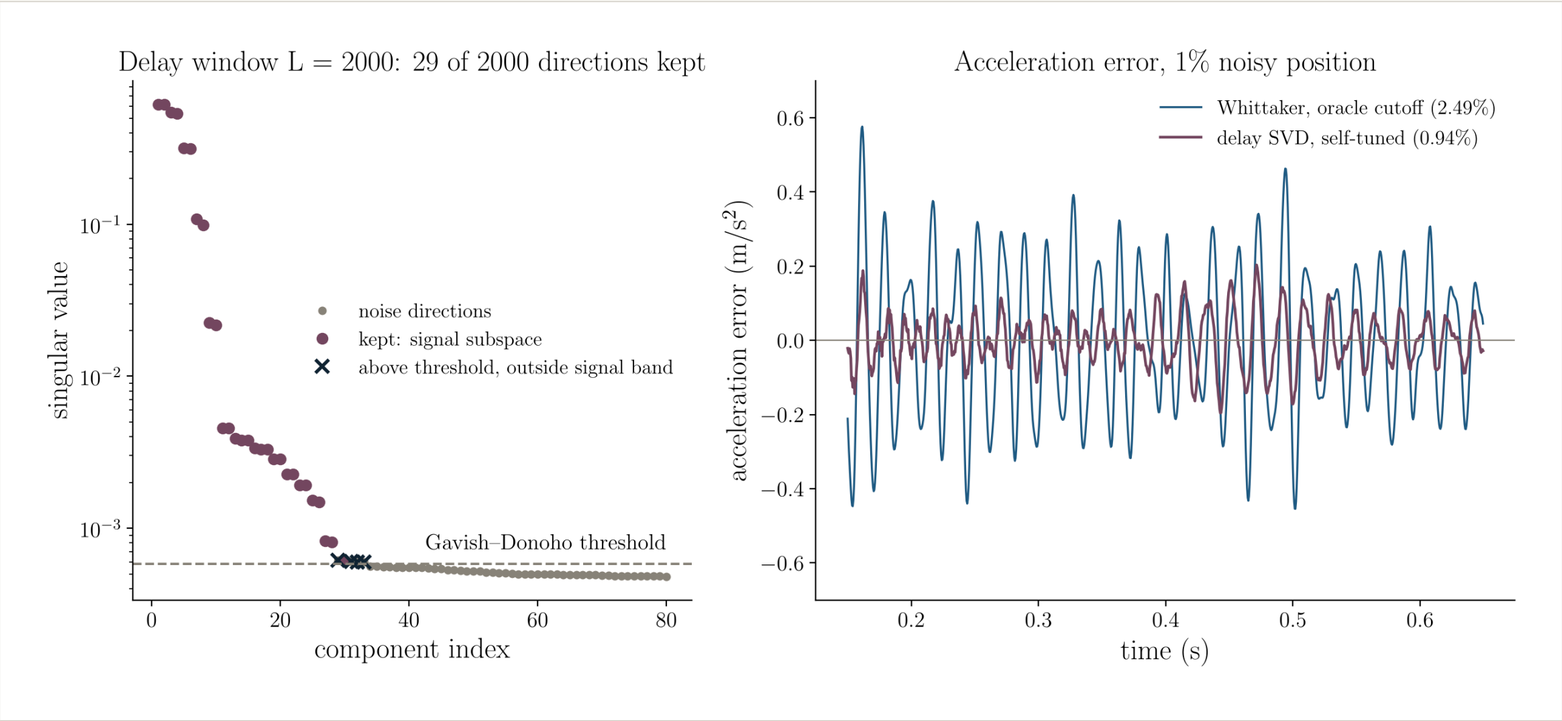
Prior: the signal lies in a low-dimensional subspace of its delay reconstruction

- **Embed:** rows of a Hankel matrix are delay vectors $(x_k, x_{k+1}, \dots, x_{k+L-1})$, window $L = N/3$.
- **Decompose:** SVD of that matrix; keep directions above the Gavish–Donoho hard threshold.
- **Guard:** drop any kept direction whose mean frequency lies above the band where the PSD clears the noise floor.
- **Reconstruct:** project, then average along anti-diagonals. Several sensors embed side by side.
- **Differentiate** the reconstruction with a fourth-order stencil. It is band-limited, so the stencil error is negligible.
- No knob: L from the record length, dimension from the threshold, guard from the spectrum.



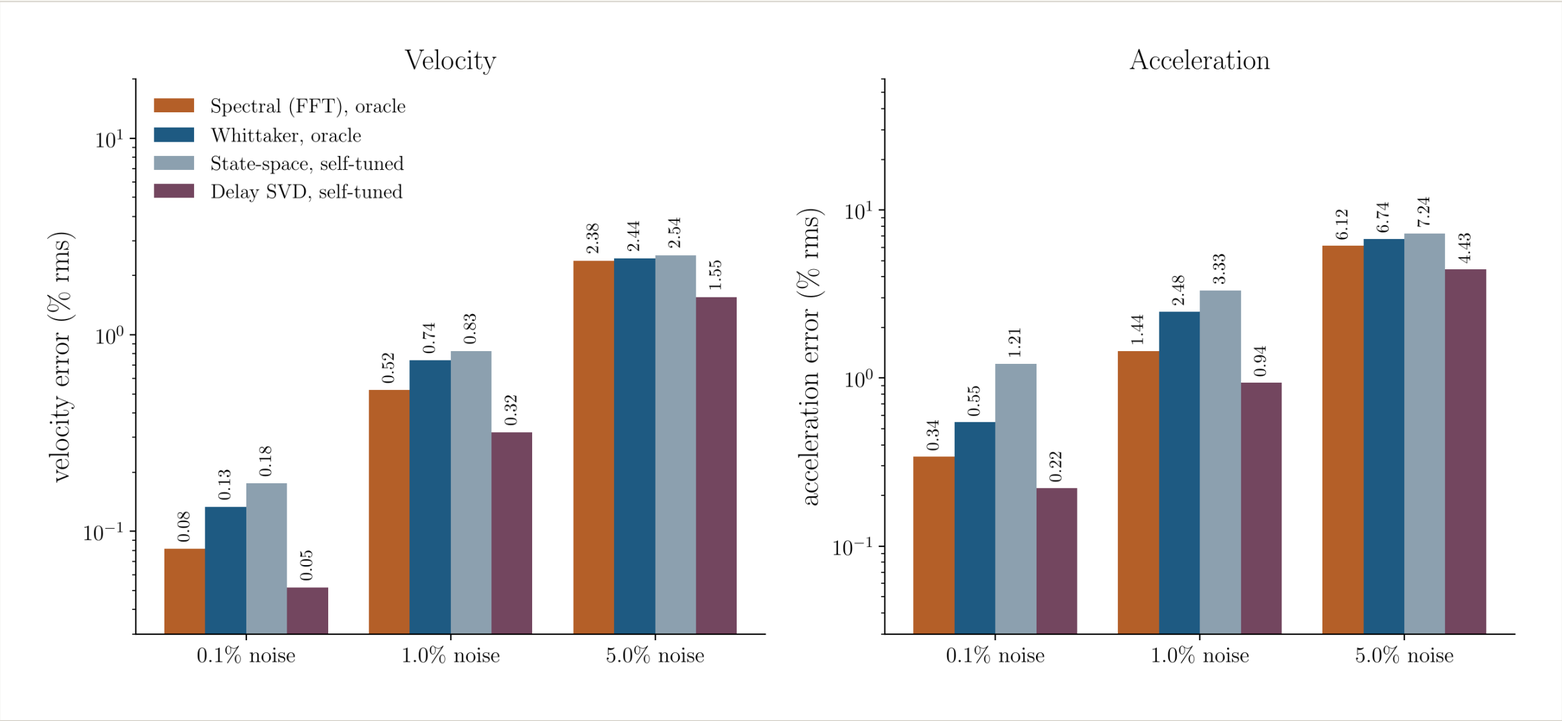
DELAY RECONSTRUCTION

29 of 2000 delay directions carry the decay



Left: singular spectrum of the trajectory matrix, 1% position noise. Right: acceleration error of the self-tuned delay estimate against Whittaker at its oracle cutoff.

Self-tuned delay SVD beats every oracle-tuned method



Duffing free decay, same noise realisations as the main benchmark. Oracle = cutoff swept against the exact answer. The delay method sees no truth.

Delay reconstruction (SSA): strengths

Project onto the signal subspace of the trajectory matrix; differentiate or integrate the reconstruction.

STRENGTHS

- No knob: window from record length, dimension from the hard threshold
- Best accuracy of any method tested on decays, by 1.4–1.6× at every noise level
- Several sensors share one subspace (multichannel SSA)
- Full-record accuracy: no FFT-style edge damage

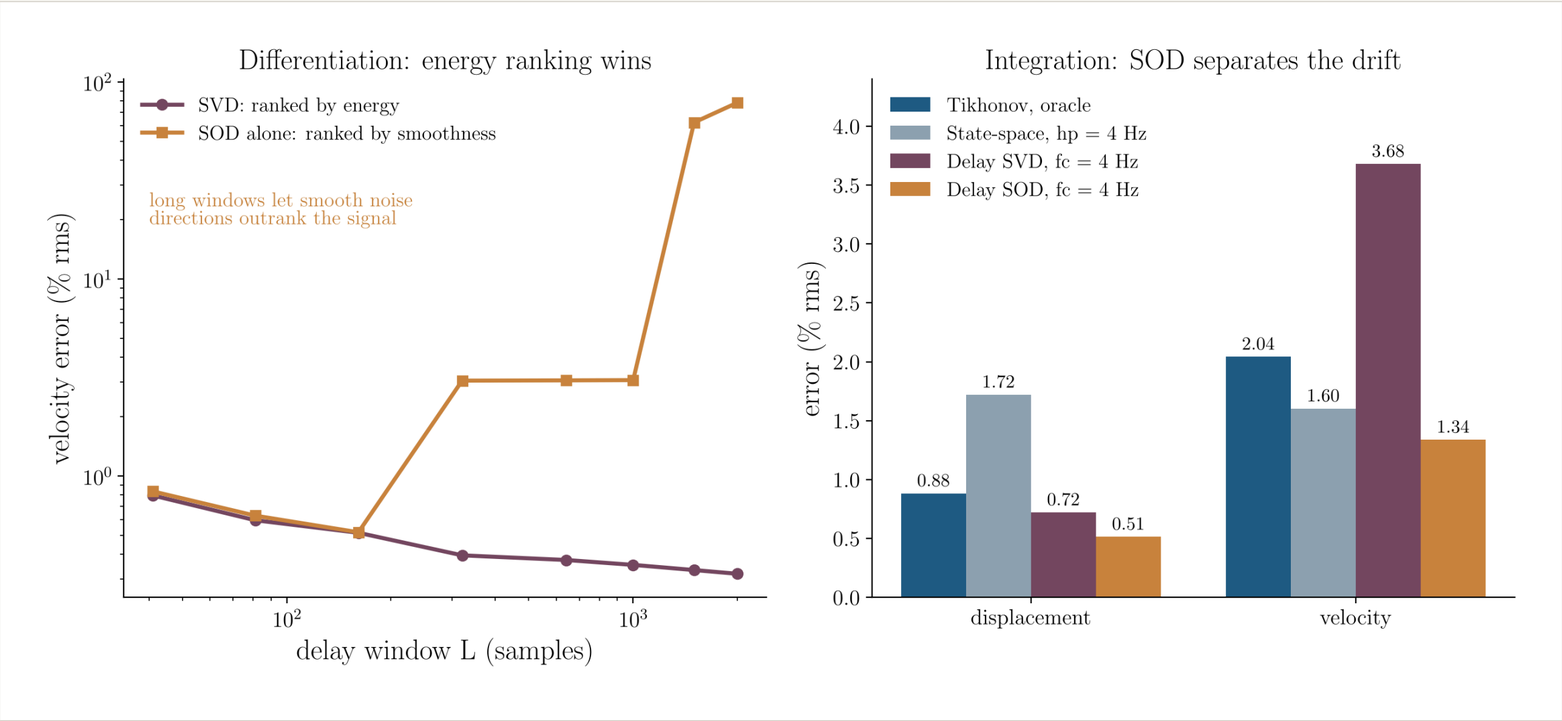
Delay reconstruction (SSA): limitations

LIMITATIONS

- The prior is quasi-periodicity: no gain at impacts (23% vs 17% for TV)
- Cost grows as $L^2 N$: about 1 s for $N = 6000$, $L = 2000$
- Needs uniform sampling and a gap-free record
- No error bars, and integration still needs a corner

Use it when The record is a free decay, a ringdown or a steady forced response.

SVD for differentiation, SOD for integration



Left: SOD alone ranks directions by smoothness, so long windows admit smooth noise. Right: SOD inside the SVD subspace orders it by frequency and isolates the drift.

Where delay reconstruction helps, and where it does not

Velocity / acceleration error, % rms; integration rows give displacement / velocity

Record	Best competitor	Delay method	Verdict
Duffing decay, 1% noise	0.52 / 1.44 spectral, oracle	0.32 / 0.94 SVD	helps
3-DOF chain, mass 3	0.95 / 2.21 Whittaker, oracle	0.38 / 0.64 SVD	helps
3-DOF chain, 3 sensors jointly	0.95 / 2.21 Whittaker, oracle	0.26 / 0.63 MSSA	small extra gain
Vibro-impact, near impacts	17.0 total variation	23.1 SVD	does not help
Drifting accelerometer	0.88 / 2.04 Tikhonov, oracle	0.51 / 1.34 SOD	helps
Drifting accelerometer	0.50 / 0.25 spectral, oracle	0.51 / 1.34 SOD	spectral wins here

03

Integration and fusion

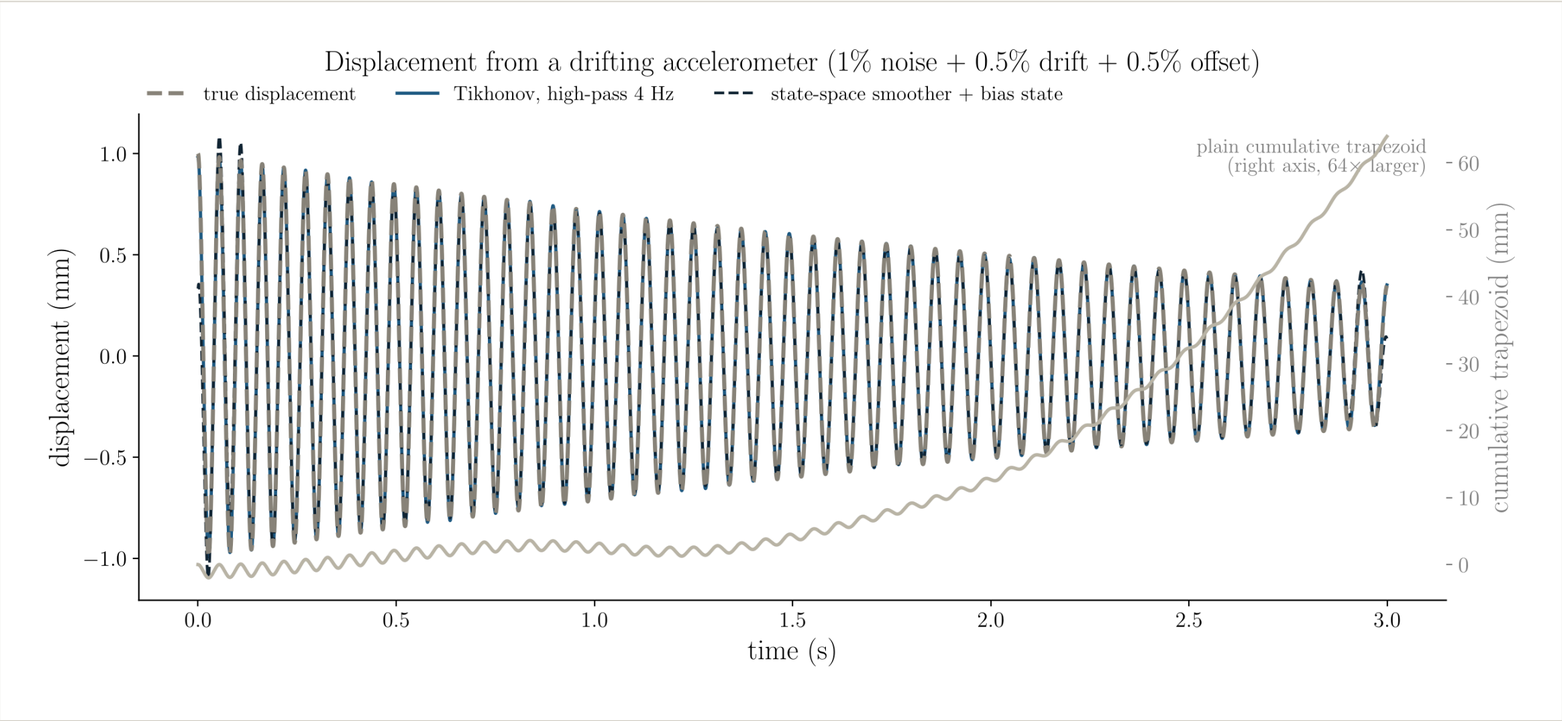


Integration has an extra problem: the constants

Two integration constants are unobservable — every method makes an assumption, so make yours explicit

- Acceleration determines displacement only up to $x_0 + v_0 t$. Those two constants are not in the data.
- A DC offset of 0.5% integrates twice into a parabola that swamps the signal within seconds.
- Every working method therefore imposes a high-pass — the question is whether it admits to it.
- **Detrend + high-pass filter:** fast, but the corner is chosen by eye and distorts the low modes.
- **Tikhonov:** the corner appears explicitly as $\lambda = (2\pi f_c)^{2n}$. One banded solve.
- **State-space with a bias state:** the corner becomes a prior on the unobservable directions.
- Choose the corner below your lowest mode of interest and above the drift band — and say what you chose.
- If you also have a displacement channel, you do not need the corner at all. That is the next slide.

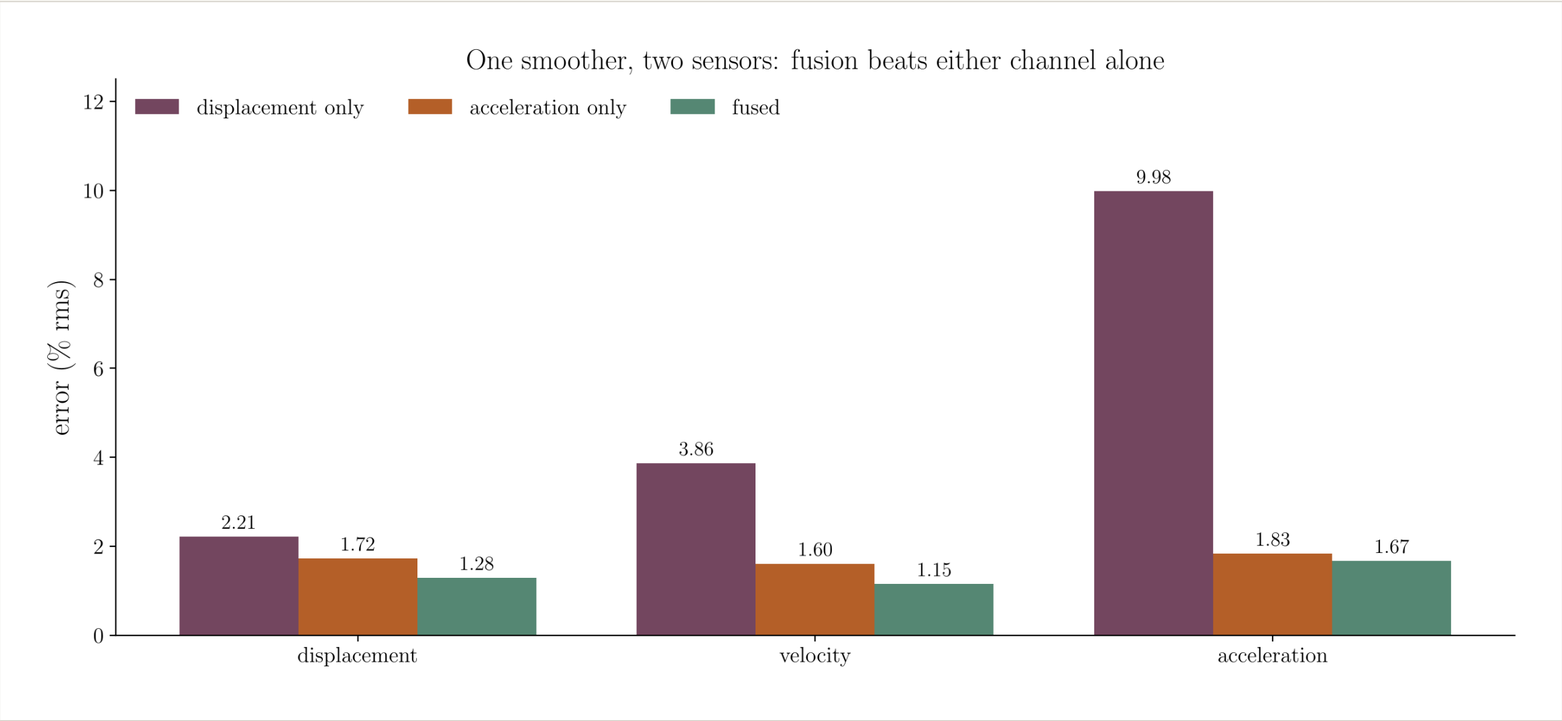
Integration done three ways



Displacement recovered from an accelerometer with 1% noise, 0.5% drift and a 0.5% offset. Regularised methods overlay the truth; the plain trapezoid needs its own axis.

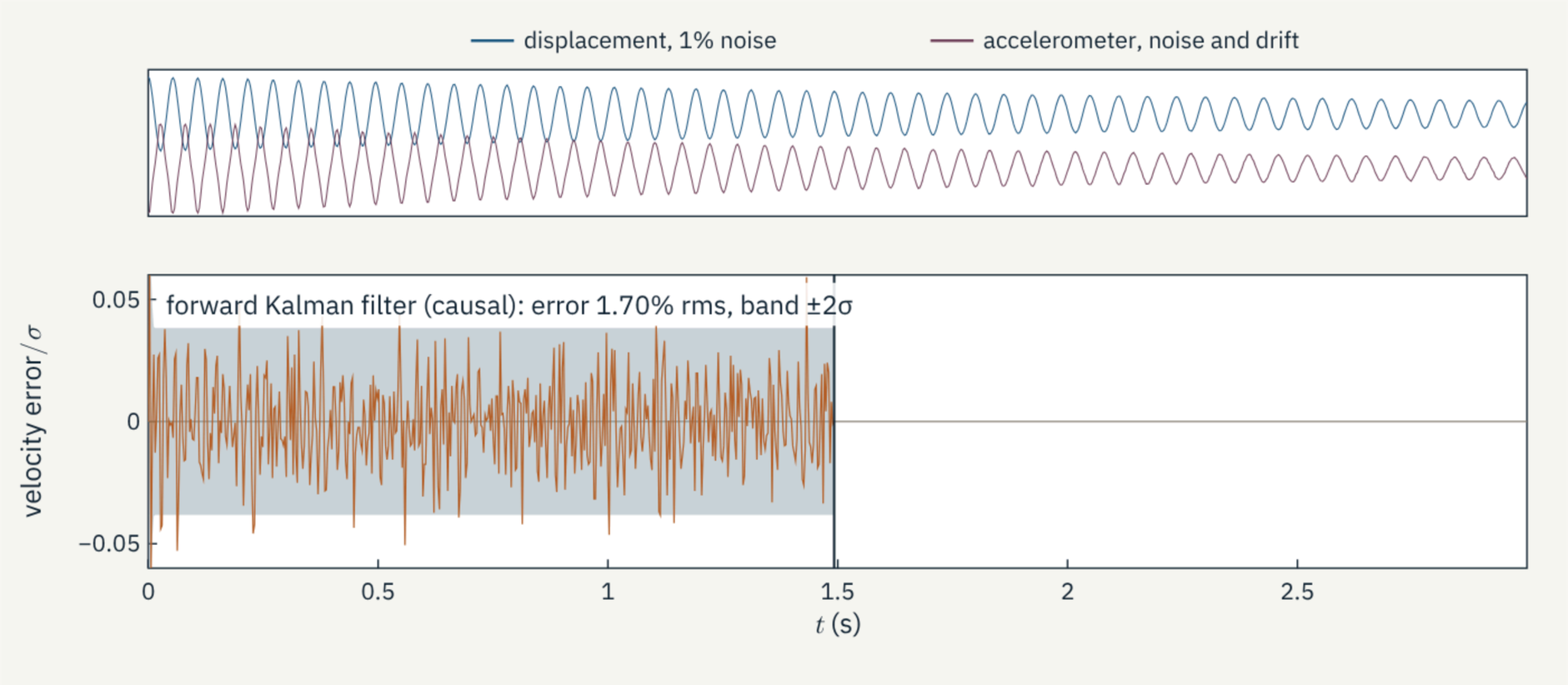
INTEGRATION

If you have both sensors, use both at once



One state-space smoother, 200 Hz displacement at 3% noise fused with 2 kHz acceleration at 1% noise plus drift.

Forward filter, then backward smoother



04

In practice



IN PRACTICE

The comparison: five classical methods

Method	Prior	Knobs*	Ends	Gaps	Error bars	Best at
Spectral (FFT)	bandlimited	1	poor	no	no	long uniform records
Savitzky–Golay	local polynomial	2	fair	no	no	quick first derivatives
Whittaker / Tikhonov	small p-th deriv.	1	good	no	no	smooth data, both directions
Smoothing spline	small p-th deriv.	1	good	yes	no	non-uniform sampling
Total variation	piecewise-const.	1	good	no	no	impacts, stick–slip

**Knobs = free parameters you must choose; three methods now set their own*

IN PRACTICE

The comparison: smoother, delay and online methods

Method	Prior	Knobs*	Ends	Gaps	Error bars	Best at
State-space smoother	integrated Wiener	0	good	yes	yes	everything else, and fusion
Delay SVD / SOD (new)	low-rank delay space	0	good	no	no	free decays, ringdowns
Kalman filter, causal (new)	integrated Wiener	0	n/a	yes	yes	online / control loops
Levant sliding mode	bounded 3rd deriv.	1	n/a	no	no	finite-time exactness

**Knobs = free parameters you must choose; three methods now set their own*

IN PRACTICE

What to actually do

A decision list, in the order the questions actually arise

- Smooth data, one sensor, want it simple → **Whittaker–Henderson**, cutoff from physics.
- Smooth data, want no knob or need uncertainty → **state-space smoother**, nstate = 4 (5 if very clean).
- Quasi-periodic record (free decay, ringdown, steady forced response) → **delay SVD**, no knob.
- Two sensors → **always fuse them in one smoother**. Never process them separately and reconcile after.
- Impacts, backlash, stick–slip → **total variation**, and check that the solver converged.
- Integrating acceleration alone → **Tikhonov or a bias-state smoother**; report the high-pass corner.
- Online or in a control loop → **the causal Kalman filter**; Levant only when you need finite-time exactness with a known bound.
- Never: a bare finite difference, or a bare cumulative trapezoid.

IN PRACTICE

Validating on a record with no ground truth

Four checks that cost minutes and one habit that costs nothing

Everything shown here was measured against an exact solution. On your data you have none — so:

- **Cross-check.** Differentiate the estimated displacement twice; compare with the measured acceleration in the band you trust.
- **Read the posterior band.** If the feature you are interpreting is narrower than $\pm 2\sigma$, it is not there.
- **Move the knob.** Change the cutoff by a factor of two either way; if the answer moves more than the band, report that.
- **Hold out a channel.** With two sensors, fit on one and predict the other — the honest test.
- **State your choices.** Method, cutoff or high-pass corner, and solver convergence, alongside the sampling rate.

IN PRACTICE

Summary

- Differentiating displacement and integrating acceleration are one ill-posed problem, not two.
- Noise amplification is a property of the operator. Every method you can choose adds a prior instead.
- So the real question is never ‘which filter’ — it is ‘what do I believe about this signal?’
- For smooth vibration data: a quadratic penalty, tuned from a cutoff in hertz.
- For a quasi-periodic record: project onto its delay-space subspace first. Self-tuned, it beat every oracle-tuned method here.
- For a genuine corner: an L_1 penalty, with the solver’s convergence checked.
- For anything else — gaps, two sensors, no time to tune, or a need for error bars: the state-space smoother.
- And if you have displacement and acceleration, fuse them. It is strictly better and it removes a knob.

Implementation

Python and MATLAB implementations of every method here, with matching names.

```
kin_diff_whittaker, kin_diff_spectral, kin_diff_savgol, kin_diff_tvreg,
kin_diff_spline, kin_diff_gp, kin_diff_levant

kin_int_tikhonov, kin_int_spectral, kin_int_trapz_detrend

kin_delay_project, kin_diff_delay, kin_int_delay — delay reconstruction, SVD or SOD

kin_smooth — differentiation, integration, fusion; causal option for online use
```

Cross-validated between the two languages: 38 of 38 checks pass, agreement 1e-16 to 1e-4.

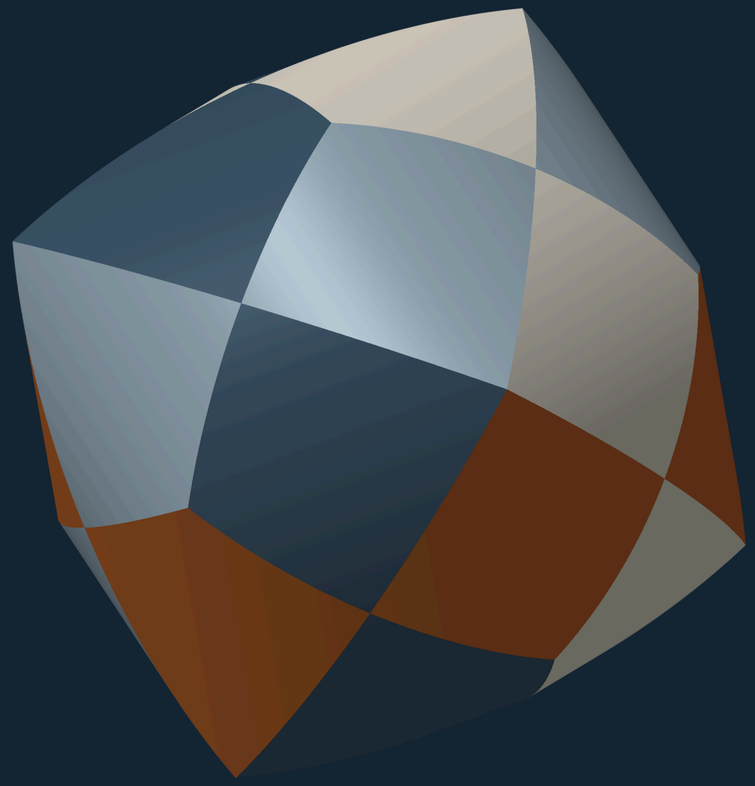
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Questions

When amplitude changes the story

github.com/nld-uri/kinematics-toolbox

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